

YOUTUBE MASTERY FROM SCRATCH 2026

BrandGoblin AI

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YouTube Mastery From Scratch (2026)

The brutally honest guide for Fox, a complete YouTube beginner, using YouTube to drive BrandGoblin AI signups.

Written July 5, 2026, from fresh 2025-2026 research. Sources with links at the bottom. Companion docs: TIKTOK_MASTERY_FROM_SCRATCH_2026.md (the same videos feed both platforms, so that doc is required reading first) and CUSTOMER_ACQUISITION_PLAN_100_USERS_30_DAYS.md (the master plan this slots into). Core premise, stated up front: in month one, YouTube is NOT a lead channel. It is the second home for videos you already made for TikTok. It costs you minutes per day and it plants seeds that pay off in months 2 through 12. This guide is honest about that everywhere.

HOW TO USE THIS DOC

Read sections 1 and 2 once, slowly. They explain how YouTube differs from TikTok, and those differences change a few of your habits. Sections 3 through 11 are checklists you come back to. If you only have ten minutes today: read section 2 (the brutal truths) and section 5 (the repurposing pipeline), because those two cover 90 percent of what you will actually do this month.

Honest promise: your 30-day short-form video goal across TikTok, Reels, and Shorts combined is 15 to 30 signups, per the acquisition plan. YouTube's share of that is realistically 3 to 10 signups in month one. Its real job is different: it is the only one of your three video platforms where content keeps working for months and where people SEARCH for exactly what BrandGoblin does. Month one plants that garden. Months 2 plus harvest it.

1. HOW YOUTUBE ACTUALLY WORKS, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

YouTube is really two different machines wearing one trench coat. You need to understand both, because they reward different things.

Machine 1: The Shorts feed (your month-one machine)

What a Short is. A Short is a vertical video up to 3 minutes long that plays in a swipe-up feed, exactly like TikTok's For You Page. The 3-minute limit is current and confirmed: YouTube raised it from 60 seconds to 180 seconds on October 15, 2024. One important side effect landed December 8, 2025: ANY video you upload that is vertical (or square) and 3 minutes or under is automatically classified as a Short. You cannot opt out. Remember this later when we talk about long-form: a long-form video must be horizontal, or YouTube will file it in the Shorts feed whether you like it or not. ([YouTube Help](#), [Descript](#))

How a new Short gets judged. Nearly identical shape to TikTok: every Short gets shown to a small test pool first, commonly cited as 50 to 500 viewers, and if it holds their attention it escalates to bigger pools. In 2026 that test pool is roughly 70 percent people who have never seen your channel, so you do not need subscribers for a Short to travel. ([vidIQ](#), [Miraflow](#))

What the Shorts algorithm grades on. Two numbers dominate everything else: 1. **Viewed vs swiped away.** The percentage of people who actually watched your Short instead of instantly swiping past it. This metric exists by name in your YouTube analytics. Above 70 percent is strong, under 60 percent is weak. ([Retensis](#)) 2. **Average view duration as a percentage.** How much of the video the average person watched. Practitioner benchmarks for getting pushed wider: roughly 65 percent retention on Shorts under 30 seconds, roughly 50 percent on 30 to 60 second Shorts. 50 to 64 percent is solid, below 35 percent means the hook or pacing failed. ([Socialync](#), [Retensis](#))

After those two: shares (the strongest single engagement signal), replays, comments, and likes, in roughly that order. Same instincts you built for TikTok apply directly. ([Retensis](#))

One accounting quirk worth knowing. On March 31, 2025, YouTube changed what counts as a “view” on Shorts: now every play counts instantly, even a half-second swipe-past. The old, stricter count still exists under the name **engaged views**, and that is the number that matters for monetization and for judging yourself honestly. Translation: your public view counts will look flattering; check engaged views in analytics for the truth. ([TubeBuddy](#), [Gyre](#))

Machine 2: Long-form (the month 2+ machine)

Long-form is classic YouTube: horizontal videos people click on from their home page, search results, or the sidebar. Ranking here runs on two different numbers: - **CTR, click-through rate:** of the people shown your video’s thumbnail, what percentage clicked it. Driven almost entirely by your thumbnail (the cover image) and title. Healthy range is 4 to 10 percent, and small channels often sit at 6 to 10 percent because early viewers are mostly subscribers. ([Humble and Brag CTR benchmarks](#)) - **Retention / average view duration:** how long people actually watch after clicking. Above 50 percent of the video watched is healthy for most content; for videos under 5 minutes aim for 60 to 70 percent. ([Humble and Brag retention benchmarks](#))

Long-form traffic comes from three doors: **search** (people typing questions into YouTube), **browse** (the home page feed), and **suggested** (the sidebar next to other videos). For a small channel, search is the honest door: browse and suggested favor channels with history, but search ranks videos by how well they answer the query, which is winnable from day one if you target searches big channels ignore. This is exactly why “how to name a business” style content is the long-form plan for BrandGoblin. ([Backlinko](#), [ProDigitalWeb](#))

The differences from TikTok that actually change your behavior

You already know TikTok. Here is precisely what is DIFFERENT on YouTube, because the rest transfers as-is:

1. **Links do not work in Shorts. At all.** Since August 31, 2023, URLs in Shorts descriptions and Shorts comments are NOT clickable. On TikTok your pinned-comment-plus-bio-link play works; on YouTube Shorts the only clickable links live on your channel page (the banner link and the About section). This single fact reshapes your whole conversion play, covered in section 8. ([YouTube Help](#), [TubeBuddy](#))
2. **Shorts have a real title, and it behaves like a search listing.** TikTok has a caption; YouTube Shorts have a title that shows up in YouTube search and even Google. Write Shorts titles like tiny search results (“AI builds a full brand in 2 minutes”), not like TikTok captions (“not the goblin naming it better than me”). Keywords in the title and description carry more weight than hashtags on YouTube. ([Hashtag Tools](#), [PostEverywhere](#))

3. **Shorts age better.** TikTok’s push is mostly a 24 to 72 hour event. Shorts keep collecting views for weeks or months through search and recommendations. Practical effect: never delete a “flopped” Short, and judge Shorts on a 7 day window, not 48 hours. ([Miraflow](#), [PostEverywhere](#))
4. **New channels ramp slower.** TikTok gives total unknowns a fair viral shot on video one. On YouTube, early distribution leans on channel history and topic signals it has not learned yet, so growth is more gradual but more durable. Expect quieter first weeks than TikTok, with less lottery upside and less flop downside. ([Miraflow](#), [FluxNote](#))
5. **No comment-reply-video button.** TikTok’s “reply with video” (your Format 2 growth loop) has no YouTube equivalent. The workaround: screenshot the YouTube comment, drop the screenshot into the video in CapCut, and it works the same. Since your comment-reply TikToks get reposted to Shorts anyway, this mostly means YouTube comments become material for TikTok-style videos, not the reverse.
6. **Trending sounds barely matter on Shorts.** TikTok’s sound culture is a ranking lever. On Shorts, your voiceover-led videos travel fine with no trending audio, and licensed music in Shorts over 60 seconds gets restricted anyway. Your voice is the audio strategy. One less thing to do per upload. ([YouTube Help](#))
7. **Subscribers mean slightly more here.** Still not the main ranking input, but YouTube’s test pool includes some subscribers, subscribers feed the long-form machine later, and YouTube counts “did this viewer subscribe after watching” as a satisfaction signal. On TikTok you were told to ignore follower count. On YouTube, treat subscribers as a small but real asset you are quietly banking for month 2. ([vidIQ](#))

One-line summary: same game as TikTok in the feed, but the links are locked, the titles are searchable, the videos live longer, and the channel is an asset that compounds instead of resetting with every post.

2. THE BRUTAL TRUTHS, UP FRONT

1. **Month one on YouTube will be quieter than month one on TikTok.** For a business channel under 5,000 subscribers, 100 to 300 views per Short in the first 48 hours is considered HEALTHY. Many of your first Shorts will do less. A realistic month across 20 to 25 reposted Shorts: a few thousand to a few tens of thousands of total views, heavily lumpy, with most Shorts under 500 views and hopefully one or two that break out. ([Humble and Brag](#), [Humble and Brag Shorts benchmarks](#))
2. **You cannot put a clickable link anywhere near a Short.** Not the description, not a pinned comment. That has been true platform-wide since August 2023 and no channel size unlocks it. Your clickable links live only on your channel page. Every YouTube viewer who signs up will either type your URL from memory, visit your channel page first, or Google you. Each step leaks people. This is the single biggest reason Shorts convert worse than TikTok for you in month one, and it is a platform rule, not a skill problem. ([YouTube Help](#))
3. **Monetization is irrelevant to your goal, and far away anyway.** The YouTube Partner Program (the thing that lets channels earn ad money) currently needs 500 subscribers plus 3,000 watch hours or 3 million Shorts views in 90 days just for the junior tier, and 1,000 subscribers plus 4,000 watch hours or 10 million Shorts views for full ad revenue. You are not chasing any of that. You monetize by people signing up at [brandgoblinai.com](#). Mention this only so you never waste an hour thinking about it. ([YouTube Help](#), [vidIQ](#))

4. **“Shorts don’t convert” is partly true and worth respecting.** The pessimist case has real numbers behind it: one widely shared analysis found under 0.2 percent of Shorts viewers ever click through to a channel’s long-form content, and Shorts audiences skew toward casual scrollers. The optimist case also has numbers: channels posting both Shorts and long-form reportedly grow subscribers around 3x faster than single-format channels, and B2B/SaaS marketers overwhelmingly report positive ROI from short-form video. The honest synthesis for you: Shorts are a cheap awareness engine and a slow subscriber drip, not a signup faucet. Expect low single-digit signups from Shorts alone in month one, and treat anything more as a bonus. ([Marketing Agent Blog](#), [AIR Media-Tech](#), [Content Beta](#))
 5. **Reposting with a TikTok watermark genuinely buries you.** This is not folklore on YouTube. YouTube runs watermark detection, and one documented test showed watermarked TikTok reposts averaging 450 views while the same content uploaded as a clean original file averaged 12,000. You already export clean files from CapCut for TikTok, so this costs you nothing extra, but it is the one repurposing sin YouTube truly punishes. ([Joyspace](#), [Socialync](#))
 6. **Sub count is vanity in month one. Two numbers are not.** Viewed vs swiped away, and average view duration percentage. Those decide distribution. Subscribers follow them. The one exception: 500 subscribers eventually unlocks the junior monetization tier and, more usefully, signals YouTube that the channel is real. Bank subs, do not chase them.
 7. **Most product channels flop for the same reason as on TikTok: they post ads.** Polished, logo-first, salesy content dies in the feed on every platform. Your TikTok instincts (raw, entertaining, product-as-payoff) are exactly right for Shorts. The channels that flop on YouTube add a second failure mode: uploading horizontal 10-minute walkthroughs with zero search targeting that nobody was ever going to find. You will avoid both.
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3. CHANNEL SETUP, STEP BY STEP

Jargon for this section. Your **handle** is your @name. The **banner** is the wide image across the top of your channel page. The **About section** is your channel’s description page, and it is one of the only places YouTube gives you clickable links. **Verification** here means confirming a phone number, which unlocks custom thumbnails and other features; it is not the gray checkmark badge.

Step 1: Create the channel (10 minutes)

1. Go to youtube.com signed in with your Google account (joeherrington369@gmail.com works), click your avatar, Create a channel.
2. **Channel name:** BrandGoblin AI. **Handle:** @brandgoblinai if free, matching your TikTok and Instagram exactly. One name across all platforms, because your voiceovers say “search BrandGoblin AI” and that search has to work everywhere.
3. Turn on two-step verification on the Google account. Same reason as TikTok: losing the account later hurts.

Step 2: Verify the phone number immediately (5 minutes)

Go to youtube.com/verify and confirm your phone. This unlocks custom thumbnails (cover images you design instead of a random frame), videos over 15 minutes, and eventually the “related video” link feature on Shorts. Do it on day one so it is never a blocker. ([Castos](#))

Step 3: Branding (30 minutes, mostly reusing TikTok assets)

- **Profile photo:** the same close-cropped Nix face you used on TikTok. It must read at 36 pixels, the size it renders on mobile. ([Subscribr](#))
- **Banner:** 2560 x 1440 pixels, but keep all text and Nix art inside the center 1546 x 423 “safe zone” or TVs and phones will crop it. Content: Nix, the one-liner (“Type your idea. Get your whole brand in 2 minutes.”), and the URL in plain text. Goblin Studio or Canva free tier can make this in 20 minutes.
- **Channel description (the About section):** write it with search keywords, because channel descriptions are indexed. Example: “BrandGoblin AI turns one sentence into a complete brand: business name, story, colors, logo art, and social content in under 2 minutes. Nix the goblin builds brands for side hustlers, Etsy sellers, and small business owners. Free to start, no card. Try it: brandgoblinai.com”
- **Links:** in channel customization, add your links. The FIRST one becomes the clickable link on your banner, so it must be <https://brandgoblinai.com/?ref=yt>. Add Instagram and TikTok after it. Sources disagree on the current maximum shown (5 vs 14); it does not matter for you, the first link is the one doing the work. ([Subscribr](#), [Accio](#))

Step 4: Upload defaults (10 minutes, saves time forever)

In YouTube Studio, Settings, Upload defaults, set once: - Default description: two lines about the product, then “Try it free, no card: brandgoblinai.com (link is clickable on our channel page)” then 3 hashtags: #Shorts #branding #aitools. The URL is not clickable in Shorts but people do read and retype it, and the same default serves future long-form where links ARE clickable. - Default visibility: Private (so you consciously publish each one). - Category: Howto & Style or Science & Technology. Pick one, stay consistent so YouTube learns the channel’s topic faster.

Step 5: Housekeeping that quietly matters

- Create one playlist now: “Nix Brands Your Ideas” and add every comment-reply Short to it. Playlists are minor SEO and give binge-watchers a rail.
- Skip the channel trailer until you have a long-form video worth featuring (month 2).
- No need for a “Brand Account” or any paid anything. A standard channel does everything you need.

Total setup: about one hour, once.

4. THE MONTH-1 STRATEGY VERDICT: SHORTS-ONLY, AND HERE IS THE MATH

Verdict: month one is Shorts-only, 100 percent repurposed from TikTok production. Zero long-form until month 2 at the earliest.

The reasoning, with numbers:

1. **The hour cost of long-form is brutal for a beginner.** Editing alone for a single 10-minute video runs 5+ hours for a beginner, and tutorial-style content with screen recordings and graphics commonly takes 6 to 12 hours total per video once you count scripting, recording,

editing, thumbnail, and title work. That is one to two full working days. ([Gling, This Girl Edits](#))

2. **Those same hours in month one are worth more elsewhere.** Per the acquisition plan, your time this month goes to the launch tour, Reddit, and the TikTok machine, which have direct evidence of producing signups in week-one timeframes. A long-form search video pays off over months (search rankings build slowly), which is exactly wrong for a 30-day sprint.
3. **Shorts repurposing costs almost nothing.** The TikTok doc already has you exporting a clean file and posting it to Shorts as step 4 of every video. The YouTube-specific extras (a searchable title, the description tweak) add 3 to 5 minutes per video. Twenty-five posts at 5 minutes is roughly 2 hours for the entire month. Any signup rate above zero makes that trade worth it.
4. **The hybrid-growth evidence is real but not urgent.** Yes, channels mixing Shorts and long-form reportedly grow around 3x faster, and the standard 2026 advice is 3 to 5 Shorts a week plus 1 to 2 long-form a month. That is your month 2+ shape, once the 30-day sprint is over and the channel has calibration data showing which topics hit. Section 6 has the on-ramp ready. ([Miraflow](#), [Aidelly](#))

What you give up by waiting: essentially nothing in the 30-day window. What you gain: a calibrated channel, a few hundred subscribers-in-progress, and real data on which BrandGoblin topics resonate before you spend 8 hours on one video.

5. THE REPURPOSING PIPELINE: FINISHED TIKTOK TO POSTED SHORT

This is the whole month-one workflow. It assumes the video already exists per the TikTok doc's system. Time per video: 5 to 10 minutes, dropping to 3 to 5 once it is habit.

Step 1: Use the clean file, always. The video comes from CapCut's export to your camera roll, never downloaded from TikTok. The TikTok download carries a watermark, and watermarked Shorts get buried (the documented 450 vs 12,000 view case). If you ever lose a clean file, re-export from the CapCut project rather than using a watermark remover; removers leave traces YouTube's detection can still flag. ([Joyspace](#))

Step 2: Check the sound. If the TikTok version used a trending TikTok sound added inside TikTok, that sound does not exist in your clean file, which is fine: your voiceover carries the video. Do not bother hunting a matching YouTube sound. If the video's whole joke depended on a specific trending sound (rare for your formats), skip posting that one to Shorts.

Step 3: Upload natively in the YouTube app. Tap the plus button, select the video, and confirm it is being treated as a Short (vertical, under 3 minutes, it will be automatically). Cross-posting between platforms carries no penalty; the platforms cannot see each other's uploads. Only the watermark matters. ([Socialync](#))

Step 4: Write a TITLE, not a caption. This is the big behavioral difference. Your TikTok caption is conversational bait. Your Shorts title is a search listing. Formula: what happens plus a keyword someone might search. Under 70 characters, keywords first. - TikTok caption: "A full brand from one dumb sentence. What should Nix brand next?" - Same video's Shorts title: "AI builds a complete brand in 2 minutes (name, logo, colors)" - Comment-reply video Shorts title: "AI brands a dog bakery in 2 minutes" (the niche words "dog bakery" are searchable gold)

Step 5: Description and hashtags. Your upload default already handles most of it. Add one video-specific line up top restating the title with different words (“Watch BrandGoblin AI turn ‘dog bakery’ into a full brand kit: business name, logo art, color palette, and story.”). Keep hashtags to 3 to 5 in the description, including #Shorts. More than 15 total and YouTube ignores all of them. Hashtags are a minor assist here, same as TikTok in 2026; the title and description keywords do the real work. ([Hashtag Tools](#), [Miraflow](#))

Step 6: Pin a comment. “It’s free, no card needed. brandgoblinai.com (not clickable here, YouTube’s rule, but the link on our channel page is).” Honest, human, and it preempts the “where’s the link” comment. The URL is not clickable but it is readable, and naming the channel-page link teaches viewers where the real door is.

Step 7: Timing, the low-stakes version. Shorts skew toward afternoon and evening viewing (rough consensus: 2 to 4 PM and 8 to 11 PM), but timing is a weak variable on YouTube for the same reason as TikTok: the feed is not chronological, and Shorts collect views for weeks. Post it whenever you post the TikTok and stop thinking about it. Consistency beats clock-watching. ([Hopper HQ](#), [PostEverywhere](#))

Step 8 (weekly, 10 minutes): the Sunday sweep. On batch day, open YouTube Studio once: reply to every comment, add new comment-reply Shorts to the playlist, and log the numbers from section 7. YouTube comments asking “brand my idea” go into the same idea pile as TikTok comments and become next week’s videos.

What NOT to change per video: no new edits, no re-cutting for YouTube, no platform-specific versions, no end screens (Shorts do not have them), no custom thumbnails for Shorts (the feed ignores them). The video is done. YouTube gets the copy.

Batching: if daily posting ever slips, YouTube Studio on desktop lets you schedule Shorts in advance. Uploading a week of Shorts on Sunday and scheduling one per day is a legitimate pattern and beats burst-posting then vanishing, which is the most damaging pattern on every platform. ([Meteorra](#))

6. THE LONG-FORM ON-RAMP FOR MONTH 2+

When the 30-day sprint ends, long-form becomes worth the hours, for one reason: **search intent**. People type “how to name my business” into YouTube at the exact moment they have the problem BrandGoblin solves. A video ranking for that search is a salesperson that works every day for years. Budget: ONE long-form video per month, 6 to 10 hours all-in as a beginner, targeting searches, not the browse feed. Find topics with the free method: type your seed words into YouTube’s search bar and write down what autocomplete suggests, because those suggestions are real searches ranked by frequency. Target the specific, lower-competition phrasings. ([SEO Sherpa](#), [Backlinko](#))

Ground rules for all three concepts below: horizontal video (remember, vertical under 3 minutes auto-files as a Short), 6 to 10 minutes long, your voiceover over screen recording (your strongest asset, no face needed), custom thumbnail, keyword in the first half of the title and the first two sentences of the description, clickable `?ref=yt` link in the description, end screen in the last 20 seconds. An **end screen** is the clickable panel YouTube lets you overlay on a video’s final seconds, pointing to another video or your channel; the best-performing layout is one video element plus one subscribe button, and business channels see 5 to 8 percent of viewers click them. ([Humble and](#)

Brag)

Concept 1: the business-name video (highest search intent, make this first)

- **Working title:** “How to Name a Business in 2026 (5 Free Methods, Tested)”
- **Thumbnail concept:** split screen. Left side: a crossed-out list of terrible generic names (“Quality Solutions LLC”) in gray. Right side: one great name in huge type on a bright green panel with Nix peeking over it, eyebrows raised. Three words of text max: “NAME IT RIGHT.”
- **Outline:** (1) Cold open, 20 seconds: show three real bad names and one great one, promise the five methods. (2) Why names get stuck: the perfection trap, one minute. (3) Methods one to four, one minute each, all genuinely useful and doable by hand: the mash-up method, the founder-story method, the “say it out loud” test, the domain-check habit. (4) Method five: let AI do all four at once, screen-record BrandGoblin naming a real business idea live, including the story behind the name, two minutes. Honest framing: “I built this tool, here is exactly what it does, the free tier does everything you just saw.” (5) Recap card plus end screen to concept 2’s video.

Concept 2: the free-logo video (biggest search volume in your niche)

- **Working title:** “How to Make a Logo for Free (3 Ways Compared, No Design Skills)”
- **Thumbnail concept:** one ugly hand-drawn logo on the left, one clean AI-generated logo on the right, a big versus arrow between them, Nix’s hand pointing at the clean one. Text: “FREE. ALL OF THEM.”
- **Outline:** (1) Cold open: the finished logos from all three methods side by side, 15 seconds. (2) Method one: Canva free tier, honest walkthrough with its real limits, two minutes. (3) Method two: the DIY font-plus-icon approach, two minutes. (4) Method three: BrandGoblin’s Goblin Studio generating logo art from the brand it already built, two minutes, again with the “I made this, free tier, no card” honesty. (5) Comparison table on screen: time, skill needed, what you get with each. (6) End screen to concept 1.

Concept 3: the full-demo video (lower search volume, highest conversion, feeds off the other two)

- **Working title:** “I Built a Complete Brand in 2 Minutes with AI (Full Live Demo)”
- **Thumbnail concept:** a stopwatch showing 2:00 next to a full brand kit spread (name, palette, logo, social post) with Nix mid-shrug. Text: “2 MINUTES. ALL OF IT.”
- **Outline:** (1) The promise and a timer starting, 15 seconds. (2) Typing one real business idea in, unedited real-time generation with your live reactions, three to four minutes; the authenticity of unedited waiting is the point. (3) Walking through every asset it made, two minutes. (4) What the free tier includes versus Pro, 30 seconds, plain and honest. (5) “The link is in the description, it is free, tell me what to brand next in the comments.” End screen to whichever of the other two performed better.

Make them in that order, one per month, months 2 through 4. Each is evergreen, each links to the others, and every Short you post can point at them with the **related video** feature: a link YouTube shows under a Short that leads viewers to one of your own long-form videos. That is the one legitimate clickable pathway out of the Shorts feed, it requires the channel verification you did in section 3, and it is set per-Short from YouTube Studio on desktop. ([vidIQ](#), [TubeBuddy](#))

7. READING THE NUMBERS

Where to look: YouTube Studio app or studio.youtube.com, Analytics, then tap any Short for its own stats. Give a Short 7 days before judging (longer memory than TikTok's 48 hours).

Shorts: the four numbers that matter

Metric	Plain-English meaning	Good for you	Bad sign
Viewed vs swiped away	% who watched instead of instantly swiping past	70%+	under 60%: first frame or first second failed
Average % viewed	how much of the Short the average viewer watched	65%+ on sub-30s Shorts, 50%+ on longer ones	under 35%: hook or pacing problem, fix before posting more of that format
Engaged views	the honest view count (watched more than a moment)	trending up week over week	huge gap between raw views and engaged views: swipe-bait numbers, not real reach
Subscribers gained per Short	new subs attributed to that video	any nonzero number, banked for month 2	consistently zero on 1,000+ view Shorts: content entertains but the channel gives no reason to stay

Benchmarks from [Retensis](#), [Humble and Brag](#), and [Shortimize](#).

Decision rules (run in the same Sunday sweep as TikTok's)

- **Do not optimize Shorts separately from TikTok.** Same videos, same formats, so the TikTok kill/keep/double-down rules already govern production. YouTube analytics get a vote only when a video behaves differently across platforms: if something flops on TikTok but runs on Shorts, note the topic, because that is a YouTube-audience signal and a future long-form candidate.
- **Watch for search-driven Shorts.** In a Short's analytics, traffic sources showing meaningful "YouTube search" traffic means the title keywords are working. Whatever that Short is about is your strongest long-form topic evidence.
- **The gap check:** if viewed-vs-swiped is fine but average % viewed is weak, the middle sags. If viewed-vs-swiped is weak, the first frame fails. Same diagnosis logic as TikTok's retention graph.

Long-form benchmarks (for month 2+, parked here so they are ready)

- **CTR:** 4 to 10 percent healthy; small channels often 6 to 10 because early impressions go to subscribers. Under 3 percent from search traffic: fix the thumbnail or title. ([Humble and Brag](#))
 - **Retention:** 50 percent average view duration is healthy for most lengths; 60 to 70 percent for videos under 5 minutes. Check the retention graph for the cliff, fix that beat next video, exactly like TikTok. ([Humble and Brag](#))
 - **End screen click rate:** 3 to 8 percent normal, 5 to 8 is a good business-channel target. ([Humble and Brag](#))
 - **Return viewers above 10 percent** means an actual audience is forming, not just passersby. ([Humble and Brag](#))
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8. TURNING VIEWS INTO SIGNUPS, GIVEN THE LINK LOCKDOWN

The funnel on YouTube Shorts has one extra leak that TikTok does not: no clickable link anywhere near the video. The honest funnel: Short, then either (a) viewer remembers and types the URL, (b) viewer taps your channel, then the banner link or About link, or (c) viewer Googles “BrandGoblin AI.” Design for all three:

1. **The verbal CTA is your whole conversion engine, and you have the voice for it.** “It’s free, no card, just search BrandGoblin AI” spoken plainly at the payoff moment. Saying the name matters double on YouTube because search is native behavior here; someone typing “brandgoblin” into YouTube or Google finds you instantly. Keep saying “free” every time; it is your strongest word per the acquisition plan.
 2. **Readable text URL everywhere.** On-screen text overlay at the payoff (“brandgoblinai.com, free”), in the description, in the pinned comment. Not clickable, still copied and retyped by the motivated few. The motivated few are exactly who signs up.
 3. **The channel page is the landing page.** Banner link first (?ref=yt), About section selling in two lines, playlist of the best demos up top. Every profile tap should meet a page that makes signing up the obvious next step.
 4. **Related video links (month 2+):** once long-form exists, set every Short’s related-video link to the matching long-form video. The long-form description holds the clickable signup link and the end screen reinforces it. This is the designed pathway: Short catches attention, long-form earns trust, description link converts. ([vidIQ](#))
 5. **Realistic conversion math, so nothing here disappoints you.** TikTok math says roughly 0.5 to 1 percent of viewers click through and 2 to 5 percent of visitors sign up. On Shorts, cut the click-through step in half again because of the link friction: 20,000 Shorts views in month one might mean 50 to 150 site visits and 2 to 7 signups. Long-form flips this completely: fewer views, but viewers chose to click a search result, links are clickable, and description-link clickers from a how-to video are warm. A single ranking long-form video can quietly out-convert a hundred Shorts. That asymmetry is the entire argument for section 6.
 6. **Track it honestly:** ?ref=yt on the channel link, watch it in your analytics alongside ?ref=tiktok. If YouTube’s line stays at zero for two weeks while TikTok’s moves, nothing is broken; the platform just has a longer fuse. Keep the 5 minutes a day and reassess at day 30 with real data.
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9. MISTAKES THAT KILL CHANNELS (THE BLUNT LIST)

Most of the TikTok blunt list applies verbatim (making ads, engagement bait, quitting during calibration, buying followers, corporate comment replies). These are the YouTube-specific additions:

1. **Uploading the TikTok-watermarked file.** The one repurposing crime with documented punishment (450 vs 12,000 views). Clean CapCut exports only, forever.
2. **Treating Shorts titles like TikTok captions.** A vibes-only caption throws away YouTube's search discovery, which is the platform's one structural gift to small channels.
3. **Putting hashtag soup in the title.** Hashtags go in the description, 3 to 5 of them; more than 15 anywhere and YouTube ignores them all.
4. **Deleting or privatizing "flopped" Shorts.** Shorts resurface via search weeks later. A flop costs nothing and might wake up.
5. **Uploading a vertical "long-form" video.** Vertical and under 3 minutes auto-classifies as a Short since December 2025. Long-form means horizontal, no exceptions.
6. **Chasing monetization thresholds.** 10 million Shorts views in 90 days is the full-monetization Shorts bar. That is not your business model. Signups are.
7. **Begging for subscribers in every Short.** "Subscribe for more" as a bare demand is the same ad-smell as TikTok engagement bait. Earn subs with the content; ask, at most, once per video softly, or not at all.
8. **Judging YouTube by TikTok's clock.** Quieter first 48 hours is the platform's normal shape, not failure. Seven-day judgments, 30-day verdicts.
9. **Building YouTube-only content in month one.** The whole economics of this channel rests on marginal cost near zero. The moment Shorts demand their own production pipeline this month, the plan is broken. One shoot, three platforms.

10. THE 30-DAY YOUTUBE CALENDAR (RIDES ON THE TIKTOK CALENDAR)

This adds no new production. Every item is minutes, layered onto the TikTok doc's calendar.

Days 1 to 3 (setup window, alongside TikTok setup): - Create the channel, verify the phone, complete branding, links, upload defaults, the one playlist. One hour total, once. - While warming up TikTok, spend 10 minutes in the YouTube app watching Shorts in your niche (search "AI tools," "small business branding") so the app learns you and you learn the Shorts flavor of your niche: slightly more explanatory, slightly less trend-driven than TikTok. ([PostEverywhere](#))

Day 4 (first TikToks ship): both videos go to Shorts via the section 5 pipeline. Searchable titles, pinned comments, done. 10 extra minutes.

Days 5 to 14: every TikTok post gets its Shorts twin the same day, 3 to 5 minutes each. Sunday sweep on days 7 and 14: reply to YouTube comments, playlist upkeep, log numbers into the acquisition plan scorecard (YouTube gets one line: Shorts views, viewed-vs-swiped average, subs, ?ref=yt signups).

Days 15 to 21 (Product Hunt week): repurposing continues on autopilot. If the launch spikes traffic, some of it will search your name on YouTube; the channel existing with 15+ Shorts is the point. The Spark Ads decision on day 18 is TikTok-only; there is no YouTube equivalent worth \$150 this month.

Days 22 to 30 (amplify week): the TikTok doubling-down (3 to 5 variations of the winner) flows to Shorts automatically. Check one YouTube-specific thing: did any Short meaningfully outperform its TikTok twin, or pull search traffic? Note the topic; that is your first long-form video's subject, possibly overriding section 6's default order. - Day 30: the honest recap. Alongside TikTok's recap video and the Reddit/X recap post, spend 15 minutes on the YouTube verdict: total Shorts views, engaged views, subs, signups at `?ref=yt`, and whether any topic earned the month-2 long-form hours.

The month's honest scoreboard for YouTube alone: 20 to 25 Shorts posted (all repurposed), 5,000 to 40,000 total views (wide because variance rules), 30 to 150 subscribers, 3 to 10 signups tagged `?ref=yt`, and one validated long-form topic. Total incremental time cost: roughly 3 to 4 hours across the entire month.

11. WHAT TO AUTOMATE OR AI-ASSIST, HONESTLY

Worth automating or delegating to AI: - **Shorts titles and descriptions.** Feed the TikTok caption and the video's topic to AI, ask for a sub-70-character searchable title plus a two-line keyworded description. This is the main YouTube-specific writing task and it is perfectly delegable; you approve, you post. - **Scheduling.** YouTube Studio's built-in desktop scheduler for the week's Shorts on batch day. Free, native, zero risk. - **Keyword scouting for month 2.** AI can expand your autocomplete findings into a candidate list of long-form search targets. Validation stays manual: you type them into YouTube yourself and eyeball what currently ranks. - **Thumbnail drafts (month 2+).** Goblin Studio or Canva plus AI-suggested layouts for A and B versions. Keep the final call human; the thumbnail is the highest-leverage 30 minutes of any long-form video.

Never automate: - **Your voiceover.** Same verdict as TikTok, stronger here: YouTube's 2026 systems actively suppress low-quality AI content, and your voice is the moat. ([BibiGPT](#)) - **Comment replies.** Small comment volume this month makes this easy: reply as Fox or as Nix, humanly, in the Sunday sweep. - **Fully AI-generated Shorts pipelines.** The faceless-automation channels are precisely what the platform is now demoting. Your repurposed, human-made content is the opposite of that and benefits from the contrast.

Rule of thumb, same as TikTok: automate the paperwork around the content, never the human inside it.

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Evidence-quality notes, stated plainly. - YouTube publishes more official documentation than

TikTok (the link rules, YPP thresholds, and 3-minute Shorts rules above are official), but the algorithm numbers (test pool sizes, retention thresholds, the 70 percent viewed-vs-swiped bar) are third-party practitioner estimates that converge across sources. Treat them as strong estimates, not physics. - The “channels mixing formats grow 3x faster / 41% faster” claims appear across several 2026 marketing blogs, some citing “YouTube internal data” without a primary source. Directionally credible, precise multipliers unverified. - The “under 0.2 percent of Shorts viewers convert to long-form” figure comes from creator-community analysis, not YouTube. It matches the broader pattern in the evidence but the exact number is soft. - Search volume numbers for “how to name a business” and logo topics could not be verified with free public data; the concepts in section 6 rest on autocomplete evidence and the density of commercial players (Looka, Canva, Adobe) competing for those searches, which itself signals real demand. Verify with your own autocomplete pass before filming. - Shorts-specific signup conversion rates for small product channels have no published benchmark anywhere I could find. Section 8’s math extrapolates from TikTok benchmarks with an added friction penalty. It is an honest estimate, clearly labeled, and your own `?ref=yt` data will replace it within 30 days.